

adding flavor

The flavor of legumes can be rather bland, so it's usually a good idea to add some aromatics. A bouquet garni (see p24) or a sprig of herbs will do the trick: bay leaves, parsley, rosemary, or thyme all work well. A pinch of cumin, cilantro, hot red pepper flakes, or caraway is another option, but you could also pop a carrot into the pan or an onion studded with cloves. Alternatively, you can cook legumes in a well-seasoned stock, but never season it with salt—it will prevent them from softening.

cooking legumes

Drain the soaked legumes, then place them in a large pan along with any seasonings. Pour in four times their volume of cold water and add 1 tbsp vegetable oil to keep them from sticking. Bring rapidly to a boil, and boil hard for 10 minutes, skimming away any foam with a slotted spoon. Lower the heat, partially cover with a lid, and simmer until tender. The cooking time will depend on the variety of legume (see right).



COOKING TIMES

Here are approximate cooking times for the legumes most commonly used in soups.

black beans	1 hour
black-eyed peas	1–1½ hours
borlotti beans	1–1½ hours
fava beans	1–1½ hours
cannellini beans	1–1½ hours
chickpeas	2–3 hours
navy beans	1½ hours
green beans	1–1½ hours
lentils (split)	25 minutes
lentils (whole)	45 minutes
pinto beans	1–1½ hours
red kidney beans	1–1½ hours
split peas	45 minutes